

1848. Minimum Distance to the Target Element

Difficulty: Easy

Link: <https://leetcode.com/problems/minimum-distance-to-the-target-element/?envType=daily-question&envId=2026-04-13>

Generated at: 2026-04-13 11:12:04

Problem:

Given an integer array `nums` (**0-indexed**) and two integers `target` and `start`, find an index `i` such that `nums[i] == target` and `abs(i - start)` is **minimized**. Note that `abs(x)` is the absolute value of `x`.

Return `abs(i - start)`.

It is **guaranteed** that `target` exists in `nums`.

Example 1:

Input: `nums = [1,2,3,4,5]`, `target = 5`, `start = 3`

Output: 1

Explanation: `nums[4] = 5` is the only value equal to `target`, so the answer is `abs(4 - 3) = 1`.

Example 2:

Input: `nums = [1]`, `target = 1`, `start = 0`

Output: 0

Explanation: `nums[0] = 1` is the only value equal to `target`, so the answer is $\text{abs}(0 - 0) = 0$.

Example 3:

Input: `nums = [1,1,1,1,1,1,1,1,1,1]`, `target = 1`, `start = 0`

Output: 0

Explanation: Every value of `nums` is 1, but `nums[0]` minimizes $\text{abs}(i - \text{start})$, which is $\text{abs}(0 - 0) = 0$.

Constraints:

- $1 \leq \text{nums.length} \leq 1000$
- $1 \leq \text{nums}[i] \leq 10^4$
- $0 \leq \text{start} < \text{nums.length}$
- `target` is in `nums`.